2200 years ago. A second tsunami may have hit this coast in the thirteenth century. Yet again, folk memory has been proved to have been based on historical fact even if one cannot exactly confirm if there indeed were another six temples in Mahabalipuram.

SAILING ON STITCHED SHIPS

As we have seen, the boom in maritime trade made India both an economic and a cultural superpower. According to Angus Maddison, the country accounted for 33 per cent of world GDP in the first century AD. India's share was three times that of western Europe and was much larger than that of the Roman empire as a whole (21 per cent). China's share of 26 per cent of world GDP was significantly smaller than India's[12]. He also estimates India's population at 75 million (compared to today's 1.2 billion).

What did the merchant fleets plying the Indian Ocean look like in this era? There were a wide variety of vessels, ranging from small boats for river and coastal use to large ships with double masts for long sea voyages. There were also regional variations. As shown in the panels of Borobodur, the Indonesians preferred a design with outriggers. However, they all seem to have shared a peculiar design trait: they were not held together by nails; they were stitched together with rope! Throughout the ages, travellers from outside the Indian Ocean world have repeatedly commented on this odd design preference. The technique persisted into modern times—locally built vessels were being stitched together well into the twentieth century. A survey of the Orissa coast by Eric Kentley in the 1980s found that boats called 'padua' were still being made by sewing together planks with coir ropes.[13] I am told that there are boat-builders who continue using this approach into the twenty-first century. Like the Harappan ox-cart, it is another example of how ancient technologies live on in India even as it adopts new ones.

It is unclear why the shipbuilders in the Indian Ocean region had such a strong preference for this peculiar technique when they had access to iron nails from an early stage. It has been suggested that it may have been the